Embark on Your Programming Journey with AMP

Here is an insight into running Apache, MySQL and PHP (AMP) on Windows. The author leads readers through his own experience to point out where the pitfalls are. This article is particularly useful for newbies venturing into AMP.

The first time I tried to create a Web app was during my college days. It was to be an application that would act like a college management system. Since I was a newbie and the project was too ambitious, I discovered that I couldn't figure things out—the app never really worked. Of the many things I do remember was the fact that I couldn't set up LAMP on my OpenSUSE box. I was a power user of OpenSUSE, yet, after a couple of days, I simply couldn't get the LAMP stack working. I then decided to stop trying and begin again on a platform that I didn't particularly like to use for development —Windows.

Starting off

Linux is not always the best platform to start on, since most people are unfamiliar with it. Even power users can get confused and not be able to set up a development environment straight away. This is one instance where you ought to stick with Windows rather than go with Linux. As a beginner who has not forayed into Web development, on Windows you can at least understand the instructions and follow them, and almost everyone you meet has some understanding of it. The ready-made packages for Windows require you to just install them to start working.

There are two ways to start off with the AMP (Apache, PHP, MySQL) stack on Windows: 1) Use a prebuilt package, and 2) Install the individual components and configure them to work with each other, manually. The first option is the easier one, which I would recommend. It is difficult to configure AMP manually on Linux as well as on Windows. This is largely due to the number of configuration files that need to be edited and the steps that have to be taken. Briefly, here are the steps you need to follow while configuring AMP manually on your system:

1. Install MySQL.
2. Configure MySQL parameters by editing the *my.cnf* file.
3. Install PHP.
4. Install the MySQL extension for PHP.
5. Edit the PHP configuration file (*php.ini*) to enable MySQL's support for PHP.
6. Install Apache.
7. Configure Apache to work with PHP.

There are chances of you getting stuck at many stages